O Indestructible One, meet me swiftly in your
Eternal embrace.[5]

Bhakti's creative effulgence was remarkable, and reached its peak, perhaps surprisingly, during the rule of the Muslim Mughal monarchs (1526 to the mid eighteenth century); the movement confirmed Hinduism's resilience in the face of Islamic conquest. But it was also much more than that: the Bhakti movement refreshed and strengthened Hindu society at a time when the state was in Muslim hands. It taught a staunch monotheism, shunned caste distinctions and rules, preached an absolute surrender to God and offered a religious experience that involved the direct realisation of God through devotion. To that extent, the Bhakti movement's reinterpretation of Hinduism resembled Islam's monotheism and egalitarianism; but its principles could also be found in the *Upanishad*s, its personal gods in the *Purana*s, and its religious doctrine was anchored in that of the Bhagavad Gita, which summons the worshipper to surrender all and take refuge in *dharma*. The emotional connection of the worshipper to God that Bhakti expressed brought the devotee to a relationship of profound love for the divine, a love that, as the Gita expressed it, combined that of a father and a son, a devoted friend for another and a lover with their beloved.

The remarkable reach of Bhakti ideas ranged from the great poets, philosophers and preachers Narsi Mehta in Gujarat to Vidyapati in Mithila and Chaitanya Deva in Bengal (who founded the Vaishnava movement in Bengal through his kirtanas, devotional songs to Krishna), Jnaneswara, Tukaram, Eknath and Namdev in Maharashtra, Basavanna in Karnataka and Thyagaraja in Tamil Nadu. The Krishna devotee Shankara Deva, after travelling extensively across India, returned to his native Assam and led a major revival of Hinduism in the north-east of the subcontinent.

In Kashmir in the late tenth century, Acharya Abhinavagupta propounded the doctrines of Kashmiri Shaivism which have profoundly influenced the practice of the faith in that state. Some of the great *acharya*s from the south, like Ramanuja, in effect established their own sects, restoring strength to the religion while transforming its practice in their areas. Basavanna, also known as Basava or Basaveshwara (c.